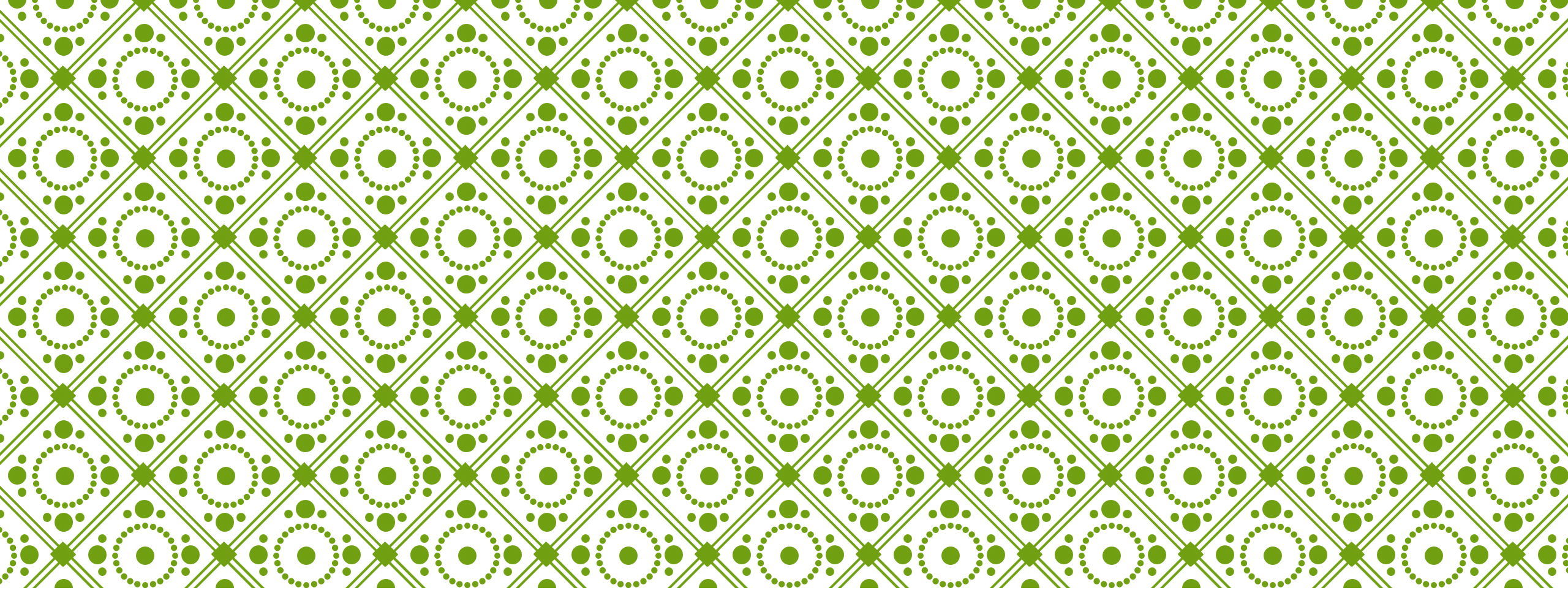


THE VANISHING HALF

Part One

READING

Read Part One „The Lost Twins“ of *The Vanishing Half* by Brit Bennett.

SUMMARY

Ask your friendly AI to give you a complete and detailed summary of Part One.

FIRST REACTIONS

Pick two questions from every box to reflect on your first impression of Part One. (see also next slide)

Personal Impressions

What was your first emotional reaction to the story or the characters?
Which scene stayed with you the most and why?
Did anything surprise or confuse you in the first part of the novel?

Character Reactions

How did you feel about Stella's decision to leave and pass as white?
Which twin did you feel closer to emotionally — Stella or Desiree? Why?
Do you see Early Jones as a trustworthy character? Why or why not?

Themes & Issues

What is your first impression of Mallard as a town and as a community?
How did your view on colorism develop while reading this part?
Which social or emotional issue in Part I seems most relevant today?

Structural/Literary Reactions

How does the opening of the novel set the tone for the rest of the story?

The book shifts between characters — did this feel engaging or confusing to you?

What do you think the title *"The Vanishing Half"* suggests after reading Part I?

Speculation & Prediction

What do you think will happen when Jude and Kennedy eventually meet?

Do you think Stella will ever return to Mallard? Why (not)?

What further conflicts or secrets do you expect in the story?

GROUP TASK: CONNECTING *THE VANISHING HALF* (PART ONE) TO U.S. HISTORY & CIVIL RIGHTS

Task Goal

Work in groups to identify the **central historical and social themes** in Part One of *The Vanishing Half* and connect them to the **Civil Rights topics** you explored in our podcast projects.



GROUP TASK INSTRUCTIONS

Step 1 – Identify Key Themes in Part One

Discuss and collect passages, scenes, or character experiences that relate to major themes such as:

Jim Crow laws & segregation

Colorism

Racial violence / lynching

Passing & identity

Internalized racism

Social mobility

Growing up under systemic discrimination

Choose **3–4 themes** that are most relevant in Part One.

Step 2 – Connect Each Theme to a Podcast Topic

For each selected theme, choose **matching podcast topics**, for example:

Jim Crow Era (1877–1950s)

Plessy v. Ferguson

Brown v. Board / Little Rock Nine

Sit-ins & Freedom Rides

MLK & March on Washington

Civil Rights Act & Voting Rights Act

Malcolm X / Black Panthers

Obama Presidency

Black Lives Matter

Identify **how the theme in the novel reflects, continues, or contrasts with the historical context** from your podcast.

Step 3 – Produce a Group Poster / Slide / Mind Map

Your product must include:

Theme (e.g., "Colorism under Jim Crow") (at least two themes per group!)

Evidence from the novel (quotation or scene description)

Connection to your podcast topic (historical explanation)

Short evaluation (4–5 sentences):

- Why is this theme significant in Part One?
- How does understanding the historical context deepen your reading?
- Is there a connection to contemporary issues (e.g., BLM)?

Step 4 – Present Your Findings

Prepare a **3–5 minute group presentation**:

Introduce your theme(s) briefly

Present your textual evidence

Show the historical connection

End with one discussion question for the class (e.g., *"How does Stella's decision to pass reflect the limited choices available to Black women under Jim Crow?"*)